JODI NO. 1

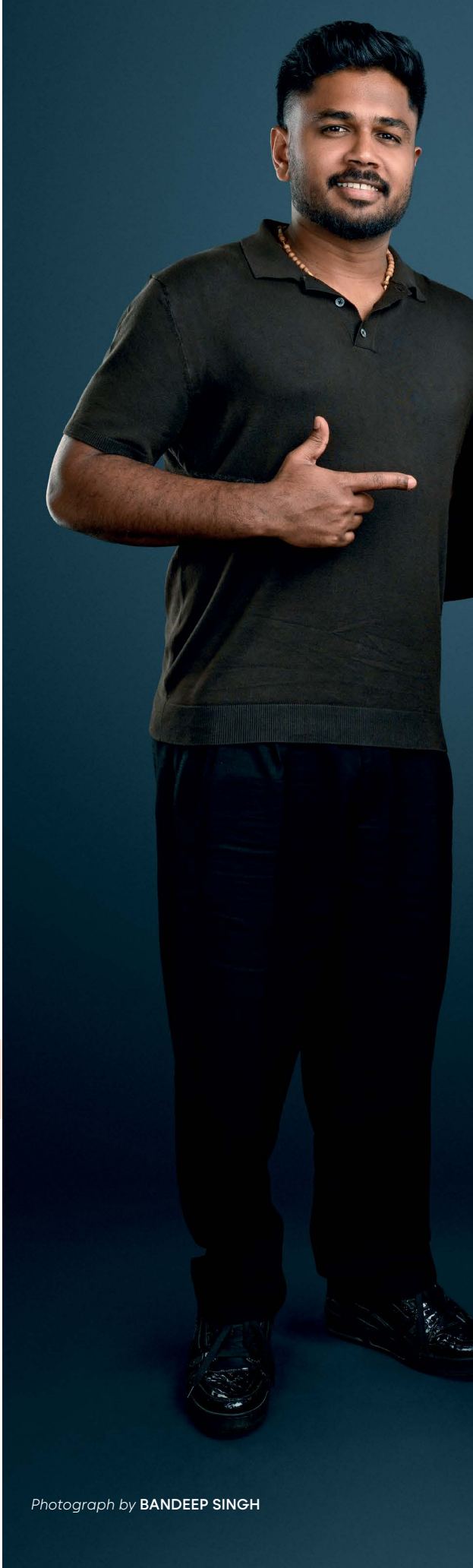
The team comes first. Everything else follows. That was the core message from India's opening pair, Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma, padded up in a relaxed, jovial and witty mood for the India Today conclave days after their T20 World Cup triumph. From July 2024, when Suryakumar Yadav took charge as T20 captain under new head coach Gautam Gambhir, Sanju revealed how the message was unambiguous: "There are no personal milestones. Every decision is taken by asking: what does the team need right now?" That had implications for Sanju, who was eventually named Player of the Tournament in the World Cup. "People may say I missed out on three hundreds," he laughed, "but a much bigger job has been done." His scores in those last three games: 97 not out, 89, 89.

For Abhishek, it was anything but smooth. He fell ill before the opening game. "I couldn't even stand properly," he recalled. Then came three consecutive ducks. But Suryakumar gave him a simple assurance—even "if you score zero in the next game as well, I'm going to make sure you play the final". "That was the confidence, that was the team environment we had—not just in this tournament but throughout the two-year journey," Abhishek said. When the pressure to perform "comes off your mind", he added, "it becomes much easier to just go out, play your game, and do well for the team". He did exactly that in the final, with a blistering 50 off 18 balls.

Sanju's setback came earlier. A poor series against New Zealand in January left his place in India's World Cup XI in doubt. "I was

SANJU SAMSON ▶
Wicketkeeper-batsman

> **I kind of feel that I am the type of person who would do much better for others than doing better for myself. So that is what I try, I learned actually**
>
> **We have a habit of always thinking about the next thing. But sometimes it's a mistake. I would rather focus on what is happening right now. I'm still trying to let it sink in**



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**